

HOW TO USE ENGLISH TENSES

Simple Present

Conjugation:

Positive Statements:

Pronoun :	To be	Modal Verbs :	Other verbs :
I (singular 1 st person)	Am	Can, Should, Could, Would, May , Might, Must	Have /work
You (singular 2 nd person)	Are	Can, Should, Could, Would, Might, Must	Have /work
He / she / it (singular 3 rd person)	Is	Can, Should, Could, Would, Might, Must	Has /works
We / you/ they (plural)	Are	Can, Should, Could, Would, Might, Must	Have /work

* We add **-es** for third person affirmative when the verb ends in **s, x, sh, ch or o**. (ex: kiss- kisses, relax –relaxes, wash-washes, watch- watches, go- goes)

* When the verb in third person (he/she/it) ends in “y” after a consonant, we remove the “Y” and add “-ies”: study – studies, carry – carries)

Negative Statements:

Pronoun :	To be:	Modal Verbs:	Other verbs:
I	Am not	Can't, Shouldn't, couldn't, wouldn't, May not, Might not , Mustn't	Don't have
You	Are not / aren't	Can't, Shouldn't, couldn't, wouldn't, Might not , Mustn't	Don't have
He / she / it	Is not/ isn't	Can't, Shouldn't, couldn't, wouldn't, Might not , Mustn't	Doesn't have
We / you/ they	Are not / aren't	Can't, Shouldn't, couldn't, wouldn't, Might not , Mustn't	Don't have

- Only the first person “I” and “we” uses “may”.

Questions:

Pronoun :	To be:	Modal Verbs:	Other verbs:
I	Am I ?	Can I ? Should I ? Could I ? Would I ? May I? Must I ?	Do I have
You	Are you?	Can I ? Should I ? Could I ? Would I ? Must I ?	Do you have?
He / she / it	Is he?	Can I ? Should I ? Could I ? Would I ? Must I ?	Does he have?
We / you/ they	Are we, you they?	Can I ? Should I ? Could I ? Would I ? Must I ?	Do we have?

When do we use the Simple Present?

We use the simple present for

1. Repeated actions /recurrent actions (habit, hobby, daily event)
I play tennis.
She always forgets her keys
2. Facts and Generalizations (fact that was true in the past is true now and will always be true. Generalization of people and things)
Cats like milk.
California is in U.S.A.
3. Present Fact (NOT TO BE CONFUSED WITH ACTIONS HAPPENING IN THE PRESENT).
I am here now.
He needs help right now.
He has his passport in his hand.

Keywords: **ALL words that indicate a certain frequency; Frequency adverbs or phrases:** often, seldom, always, never, sometimes, normally, usually, generally, frequently, rarely, regularly, occasionally, hardly ever, constantly, continually, infrequently, intermittently, periodically, now and then, almost never, quarterly, weekly, every week, every month, monthly, every year, annually, once in a while, once in a blue moon.

FUTURE FORM: *The simple present is used to make statements about events at a time later than now, when the statements are based on present facts, and when these facts are something fixed like a time-table, schedule, calendar.*

- The plane **arrives** at 6pm tomorrow.
- The restaurant **opens** at 7.30 tonight.
- Next Thursday at 2.00, there **is** an English exam.
- The plane **leaves** in ten minutes.

Present Progressive/Continuous: [to be + present participle]

Conjugation:

Pronoun	Affirmative	Negative	Questions
I	Am working	Am not working	Am I working?
He/ She/ It	Is working	Isn't working	Is he/she/it working?
We / you/ They	Are working	Aren't working	Are we/ you/ they working?

When do we use the Present Progressive (AmE) / Continuous (BrE)?

We use the Present Progressive for

1. Actions happening right now.
You are learning English now.
I am standing and you are sitting.
2. Longer actions currently in progress, but not necessarily at this moment.
I am not studying to become a doctor.
I am reading a very interesting book.
3. Repetition and irritation with "always" & "constantly"
They're always complaining, that annoys me.
He is constantly talking; I wish he would shut up.

Keywords: Now, look! Listen! Right now. Currently. At the moment, at present, at the present time, at this time, presently, in this day and age, nowadays, these days etc.

4. FUTURE FORM: We use the present progressive to talk about things in the future arrangements and commitments. (definite Future plans)

- We are having a party next week.
- I'm flying to New York tomorrow morning

Simple Past: [verb + **ed**] or irregular verbs.

Conjugation:

Affirmative:

Pronoun :	Irregular verbs : To be to see	Regular verbs :
I	Was saw	Work ed Live d
He / she / it	Was saw	Work ed Live d
We / you/ they	Were saw	Work ed Live d

* Verbs ending in **consonant+y**, remove the **y** and add **-ied** – (ex: **study** – **studied**) Verb to be, modal verbs and can **DO NOT USE DID or DIDN'T!!! CAN becomes COULD!!!** (Study list of irregular verbs!!!) verbs that end in **vowel + y**, get **ed** only. play – played

Negative:

Pronoun :	Irregular verbs : To be to see	Regular verbs :
I	Wasn't didn't see	Didn't Work Didn't Live
He / she / it	Wasn't didn't see	Didn't Work Didn't Live
We / you/ they	Weren't didn't see	Didn't Work Didn't Live

Questions:

Pronoun :	Irregular verbs : To be	Regular verbs :
I	Was I...?	Did I Live ...?
He / she / it	Was he/she/it...?	Did He / she it Live ...?
We / you/ they	Were we/you/they...?	Did we/you/they Live

*Questions words: why, where, when, what, how, who, how often, how old....comes before the auxiliary verb.

When do we use the Simple Past?

We use the Simple Past for

1. Actions that started and finished at a specific time in the past and has no connection to the present. (or a series of completed actions)

I saw a movie yesterday.

I finished work, walked on the beach, and found a nice place to swim.

2. Past facts and generalizations.

She didn't like tomatoes before.

People paid much more to make cell phone calls in the past.

Keywords: yesterday, ago, in 2015 (year), on Tuesday (day), at 2 pm (time), when I was younger, last month, last week, last year.

(All expressions that indicate a certain time in the past!)

Past Progressive: [to be + present participle]

Conjugation:

Pronoun	Affirmative	Negative	Questions
I	Was working	Wasn't working	Was I working?
He/ She/ It	Was working	Wasn't working	Was he/she/it working?
We / you/ They	Were working	Weren't working	Were we/ you/ they working?

When do we use the Past Progressive (AmE) / Continuous (BrE)?

We use the Past Progressive for

1. An action happening in the middle of another action.
I was watching TV **when she called**.
She was washing the dishes **when suddenly she heard a loud noise**.
2. An action happening at a specific time in the past.
Last night at 6 pm, I was eating dinner.
I was cleaning my house yesterday in the afternoon.
3. Parallel actions
I was studying **while he was making dinner**.
I wasn't paying attention **while I was writing the letter**.
4. Past Repetition and irritation with "always" or constantly
They were always complaining that used to annoy me.
He was **constantly** talking; I wished he would shut up.

Keywords: suddenly, while, when

Present Perfect: [to have + past participle]

Conjugation:

Regular verbs:			
Pronoun	Affirmative	Negative	Questions
I	have worked	Haven't worked	Have I worked?
He/ She/ It	has worked	Hasn't worked	Has he/ she / it worked?
We / you/ They	have worked	Haven't worked	Have we/you/they worked?
Irregular verbs: (to go)			
Pronoun	Affirmative	Negative	Questions
I	have gone	Haven't gone	Have I gone?
He/ She/ It	has gone	Hasn't gone	Has he/ she / it gone?
We / you/ They	have gone	Haven't gone	Have we/you/they gone?

- See list of irregular verbs

When do we use the Present Perfect?

We use the Present Perfect for

1. An action that happened in the past without specific time. (The time is unclear, unknown or not important.)
I have seen that movie twenty times.
I have been to France.
2. An action that started in the past and continues up to the present moment. (WITH NON-CONTINUOUS VERBS)
I have had a cold for two weeks.
She has been in England for six months.
3. An action that happened in the past with an effect on the present.
She's lost her keys.
He's broken his finger.

Keywords: just, already, since, for, up to now, so far, never, ever, not...yet.

Been vs. Gone in the present perfect!!!

*** He has been to England (Means that he went to England in the past but he is not there anymore)

*** He has gone to England (Means that he went to England and he is still in England)

Present Perfect Progressive: [to have + been + present participle]

Conjugation:

Pronoun	Affirmative	Negative	Questions
I	have been working	Haven't been working	Have I been working?
He/ She/ It	has been working	Hasn't been working	Has he/ she / it been working?
We / you/ They	Have been working	Haven't been working	Have we/you/they been working?

When do we use the Present Perfect Progressive / Continuous?

We use the Present Perfect Progressive/ Continuous for

1. The present perfect continuous (also called present perfect progressive) is a verb tense which is used **to show that an action started in the past and has continued up to the present moment**. The present perfect continuous usually emphasizes duration, or the amount of time that an action has been taking place. (WITH CONTINUOUS VERBS ONLY)

They have been talking for a long time.

She has been working at the company for five years.

Keywords: up to now, for a long time, all day

Past Perfect: [to have +past participle] – Past before Past

Conjugation:

Regular verbs:			
Pronoun	Affirmative	Negative	Questions
I	had worked	Hadn't worked	Had I worked?
He/ She/ It	had worked	Hadn't worked	Had he/ she / it worked?
We / you/ They	had worked	Hadn't worked	Had we/you/they worked?
Irregular verbs: (to go)			
Pronoun	Affirmative	Negative	Questions
I	had gone	Hadn't gone	Had I gone?
He/ She/ It	had gone	Hadn't gone	Had he/ she / it gone?
We / you/ They	had gone	Hadn't gone	Had we/you/they gone?

- See list of irregular verbs

When do we use the Past Perfect?

We use the Past Perfect for

1. Completed action before something/ another action in the past. (past before past)

I did not have any money because I had lost my wallet.

Norton had eaten breakfast when he left for work.

2. Duration before something in the past (non –continuous verbs)

He had had that car for ten years when it broke down.

By the time Alex finished his studies, he had been in London for eight years.

Keywords: before a simple past action or after a simple past action

Past Perfect Progressive: [to have + been + present participle]

Conjugation:

Pronoun	Affirmative	Negative	Questions
I	had been working	Hadn't been working	Had I been working?
He/ She/ It	had been working	Hadn't been working	Had he/ she / it been working?
We / you/ They	Had been working	Hadn't been working	Had we/you/they been working?

When do we use the Past Perfect Progressive / Continuous?

We use the Past Perfect Progressive/ Continuous for

1. Duration before something/ an action in the past.

They had been walking for over an hour when Tony arrived.

She had been working at that company for ten years when it went out of business.

2. Causes of something in the past.

Jason was tired because he had been jogging.

Sam gained weight because he had been overeating.

Keywords: before a simple past action or after a simple past action



(NOT SO) SIMPLE FUTURE:

Form 1: WILL [will + basic form of the verb]

1. We use will for predictions (we think something will happen)
 He **will** be a good doctor.
 I believe they **will** win this match.
2. We use will for instant decisions. (taken while speaking)
 A: "We don't have sugar."
 B: "I **ll** buy some then."
3. We use will for promises and refusals.
 I **will** help you, but I **won't** lend you any money. (will not)
4. We use will for offers and sometimes for suggestions.
 I **will** carry your bag / **Shall** I carry your bag?
Shall we eat out today?
5. We occasionally use will for requests:
Will you open the door please?

Form 2: Be going to [am/is/are + going to + basic form of the main verb]

1. We use “be going to” for predictions (we see present evidence)
Slow down! We are going to have an accident!
Look at the clouds, it’s going to rain.
2. We use “be going to” for decisions taken before now (intentions / plans)
Are you going to watch the game tonight?

Form 3: Present Progressive (Look at present progressive on page 5)

1. We use the present progressive to talk about things in the future that we have already arranged to do.
We are having a party next week.
I’m flying to New York tomorrow morning

Form 4: Simple Present (Look at page 1)

1. We use the simple present with timetabled event in the future.
The airplane leaves at four o’clock.
The exams start next week.
2. We use the simple present with Future time clauses (when/ as soon as / until etc.)
I’ll retire when I am 70. (NOT: ~~When I will be 70.~~)
Call me as soon as you arrive.

Form 5: **FUTURE POSSIBILITIES with MAY and MIGHT**

1. We use may or might to talk about future possibilities
I might go to the party tomorrow, I’m not sure.
Temperatures might drop next week.

Keywords: Tomorrow, next week/month/year, in x days/weeks/months/years

Future Progressive:

Will; [will be + present participle]

Be going to; [am/is/are + going to be + present participle]

1. We use the future progressive for actions that will be in progress at a certain time in the future.
He's going to be staying at the Madison hotel, if anything happens you can contact him there.
We will be driving through the dessert tonight at midnight.
2. We use the future progressive to express an action that will happen in the future because it normally happens.
I will be sleeping when he arrives tonight.
I'm going to be studying in the afternoon.

Keywords: this time (tomorrow/next week/ next month/ next year)

Future Perfect:

Will; [will have + past participle]

Be going to; [am/is/are + going to have + past participle]

1. We use the future perfect for an action that will already have happened before a certain time in the future.
By next November, I will have received a promotion.
By the time, he gets home, she's going to have cleaned the entire house.
I'm going to have finished this test by three o'clock.
2. We also use the Future perfect for duration of something in the future.
I will have been in London for six months by the time I finish my course.
By Monday, Susan is going to have had my books for a week.

Keywords: by the time..., by the end of...

Future Perfect Progressive:

Will; [will have been + Present participle]

Be going to; [am/is/are + goin to have been + present participle]

1. We use the future perfect progressive for actions that will already have happened before a certain time in the future, with emphasis on the duration.
They will have been talking for over an hour by the time Thomas arrives.
She is going to have been working at that company for ten years when it finally closes down.

VERB TENSES IN ENGLISH

